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Useful Tips When Sourcing/Renting your Accommodation

SMU does not offer accommodation for international exchange or visiting students. Students source and arrange their own accommodation based on individual budget and needs. One of the popular accommodation choices for students are rental of condominiums or apartments in the vicinity of the SMU campus. **Airbnb is not a recommended option as residential properties in Singapore are not allowed to be used for short-term accommodation under the law.**

Rental/lease of accommodation are negotiated privately and is solely between the property owner/service provider and tenant. SMU shall not be held liable nor stand to represent either party, in any disputes or legal issues arising from the lease/tenancy of the property. All parties that enter into a lease/tenancy agreement do so at their own discretion.

In order to help students in their preparation to secure accommodation in Singapore, listed below are some useful information and tips to pay attention to when renting/leasing their accommodation. The information may help you identify and avoid some common pitfalls.

MANAGE YOUR EXPECTATIONS

#1 Cost of accommodation in town/city area

Rentals for apartments and condominiums in the city area would cost more by virtue of their location in the city. Similarly, accommodation near the Mass Rapid Transit (MRT) Stations – Singapore’s subway/metro system, would also be more costly by virtue of their convenient location. If the cost of accommodation is one of your primary concerns, you may consider options further away from the city area. As Singapore has an efficient public transportation network and system, it will be easy to commute to the university.

#2 The term “fully-furnished apartment” may differ for each property

Generally, a fully furnished apartment would only include all basic furniture. These items would mainly be the living room sofa, dining room table and chairs, beds, cupboards, refrigerator and washing

machine/dryer only. One should not expect items such as pillows, linen, towels, hair-dryers, as well as personal items such as body wash and shampoo to be provided as well. Unlike a serviced apartment, leased properties do not include housekeeping services.

It is also important to clarify if the rental of the fully-furnished property includes utilities such as electricity, water, gas and Wi-Fi.

Nevertheless, you may try negotiating with the property owner to provide more items for the apartment e.g. kitchen utensils, appliances, etc.

#3 Sharing with house/roommates

In managing the cost of living, many students would group and rent a property together. In line with the regulations for rental of property, a typical apartment with three bedrooms would house six tenants comfortably. Each member of the group should play a part to be courteous and respectful to each other to ensure a harmonious and pleasant living environment in the shared space.

It would also be encouraged to select one main tenant to play the role of liaison amongst the other tenants with the property owner. The liaison would be responsible for ensuring that communication flows both ways and to be responsible for the timely collection and payment of rent.

DUE DILIGENCE

#1 Familiarise yourself with Singapore's regulations on rental of accommodations

Under the Singapore law, short-term accommodation is defined as stays of less than three consecutive months. All residential properties in Singapore (e.g. condominiums, apartments) are not allowed to be used for short-term accommodation. Any individual found guilty will minimally face a fine of up to S\$5,000.

More information can be found on Singapore's Urban Redevelopment Authority [website](#).

#2 Conduct a thorough research on the options for accommodation

Relying on photographs of the property alone may be risky, as photos may not accurately represent its actual state and condition. Ideally, you should physically visit and survey the shortlisted property(s) before committing to the lease, by arranging to arrive in Singapore in advance before the study term.

If the option above is not feasible, below are some recommendations for consideration:

- Request for a virtual tour of the property from the landlord or service provider.
- Read reviews and cross-reference with more sources to get as much information on the property. Some of these websites are propertyguru.com, 99.co, etc.
- Seek advice from your seniors who have studied abroad in Singapore. Their experience would be beneficial in sharing useful tips on the rental of student-friendly accommodation.

- Engage real estate agencies to help you in your search for accommodation.

IMPORTANT:

- It is important that you seek services from agencies that are more established and reputable.
- Such engagements would incur additional service fees and/or commission to the agencies.

#3 Read the lease agreement carefully

Be thorough and careful when reading all the terms and conditions to ensure that you fully understand the clauses and obligations of the lease agreement, before signing on or making a deposit payment. Do not hesitate to seek clarifications if you have any doubts.

Any lease or tenancy agreement committed in signature shall be binding between both parties. You have a legal obligation to adhere to the terms once the lease agreement has been finalised and accepted by both parties.

Similarly, it is your duty to find out your rights under the lease agreement. It is your responsibility to seek clarification on any clauses in the agreement, if in doubt.

#4 Do not be pressured into signing/committing to the lease agreement

If you are not comfortable with the property or are having doubts on the terms of the agreement, do not be pressured into signing or committing to the lease, even if being told that the property is in high demand with many prospects waiting to rent the place. Be prepared to give up and walk away from the deal to explore other options.

#5 Do not rely on verbal agreements

Verbal agreements are often very difficult to prove in cases of disputes arising from your lease or tenancy of the property. Hence, it is important for you to protect your interests by ensuring that even the most minor of agreements are confirmed and documented in writing in the lease agreement.

IMPORTANT:

- Any agreements from the negotiations should be documented and included in the lease agreement.
- Subsequent agreements after the lease have been signed should be included as an addendum to the main agreement and acknowledged by both parties again.

#6 Contents of the lease/tenancy agreement

The Lease/Tenancy Agreement is a legal contract that sets out the rules which the property owner and tenants agree to follow in their rental relationship. Be sure your agreement complies with all relevant

policies and local laws including occupancy rules, immigration policy, property management rules and regulations, security deposits, notice requirements for entering rental property or rules for changing or ending a tenancy, amongst others. Here are some of the most important items to pay attention to:

a. Names and Particulars of Property Owner and Tenant(s)

The names, passport or National Registration Identity Card (NRIC) Number, corresponding addresses and contact details of both Property Owner and Tenant(s) should be documented in your lease agreement. This makes each party traceable or contactable at all times in compliance with the terms of the tenancy.

b. Terms of the Tenancy

Ensure that the terms and period of the lease are stated clearly and accurately in the agreement.

c. Rent

The agreement should specify the amount of rent, payment due date as well as method of payment.

d. Advanced and Security Deposits

The respective amounts of the advanced and security deposits are usually stated. These will only be payable upon signing of the lease agreement.

Advanced Deposit: Required as a form of commitment to the lease. Usually functions as an advanced rental for either the first month or the last month, or as stated in the lease agreement.

Security Deposit: Functions as a form of 'security' for the property owner to safeguard against any damages to the property and its furnishings. The security deposit will be refunded when the property is handed back to the owner in its original condition.

e. Utilities, Wi-Fi and Cable Television

Depending on the rental package, the amenities above may already be included. If not, the tenant may negotiate and request for the necessary amenities to be included in the rental amount as a package.

f. Repairs and Maintenance

Tenants are responsible for the proper use of the leased property and to ensure that the original condition is maintained. Discuss and negotiate the terms for maintenance as well as any related costs for minor and major repairs and damages during the lease period.

g. Inventory List

It is advised for an inventory list to be included in the agreement, to list all the items and furnishings and their original condition provided under the lease. Both the property owner and tenant(s) are encouraged to go through the list together when collecting the keys upon moving in, as well as when returning the keys upon handover of the property.

h. Early Termination and Notice

It would be prudent to include an early termination clause in the agreement to safeguard both parties' interest. It is important that either party be aware of each other's rights and obligations should either party not be able to fulfil the lease for the entire duration as stipulated under the agreement.

Example:

- Student (tenant) withdraws from the exchange/visiting programme prematurely to return to their home country.
- Property owner takes over the property before the lease period is due.

IMPORTANT:

- If leasing the property as a group, ensure that each member of the group understands their obligations and agrees to the terms in the lease agreement.
- **Do not sign** the lease agreement until you have **read** and **understood ALL** the **terms** stated in the agreement. Seek clarification if in doubt.
- **ALWAYS** request for a copy of the final lease agreement and inventory list, signed by both parties. It is within your interests and rights to retain a copy as a tenant.

#7 Making a deposit/rent payment

An advanced deposit (usually equivalent to a month's rent) will be required upon signing the lease agreement, as a form of commitment. The deposit also functions as an advanced rental to cover the rental of either the first month or the last month, or as stated in the lease agreement. In the interests of the tenant, it is strongly advised against making any deposit payments prior to signing the lease agreement.

IMPORTANT:

- Always request a receipt or acknowledgement as proof of payment.

#8 Return of the housing/security deposit

It is common for the property owner to request to hold an amount equivalent to a month's rent, as a housing/security deposit. This deposit aims to cover any expenses for damages to the property and its furnishings. The terms of the return of the deposit back to the tenant(s) should be properly negotiated and duly included in the lease agreement. The deposit should be refunded to the tenant(s) after the handover of the keys and the property back in its original condition to the property owner. As otherwise stated in the agreement, the deposit will be forfeited, or not be refunded in whole, if there are any damages sustained to the property or its furnishings.

It is encouraged to inform the owner/agent of the date of departure so that the last tenant to leave can arrange for the return of the keys as well as to collect the security deposit.

#9 Document the state of the property and its furnishings at the start and end of the tenancy period

When first moving in, it is important to inspect the property together with the owner and to request for an inventory list detailing all the items and furnishings, as well as their condition. The same inspection should be done again at the end of your tenancy to ensure that the property is handed back in its original condition.

IMPORTANT:

- Take photos as supplementary records to the inventory list, especially on existing damages.
- Should any defects/damages occur during your tenancy, immediately inform the owner in a timely manner. Defects may start-off small but may worsen over time, if not rectified promptly.
- Negotiate and include the terms in the agreement for maintenance works as well as any related costs for minor and major repairs and damages during the lease period.

PRIVATE HOSTEL OPERATORS AND RENTAL WEBSITES

<http://www.yoha.com.sg>

<https://www.99.co/singapore/rent>

<https://www.propertyguru.com.sg/property-for-rent>

<https://www.srx.com.sg/singapore-property-listings/property-for-rent/residential>

<https://sg.carousell.com/categories/property-102/housing-rentals-229/>

Kindly note that the websites listed above have no affiliation with SMU whatsoever, and do not represent an endorsement by SMU in any way, so students are advised to check out the accommodation themselves before committing to ascertain their suitability.

FEEDBACK OR COMPLAINTS:

Council for Estate Agencies (CEA)

The Council for Estate Agencies (CEA) was formed on 22 October 2010 as a statutory board under the Ministry of National Development.

Established under the Estate Agents Act, CEA is empowered to administer the regulatory framework for the real estate agency industry. In addition, CEA is committed to raise the professionalism of the real estate agency industry through collaborative efforts with the industry on professional development programmes and protect the interests of the consumers through targeted public education schemes.

CEA Customer Service hotline:

1800 643 2555

+65 664 32555 (for overseas calls)

Website: www.cea.gov.sg

Institute of Estate Agents (IEA)

IEA is the national real estate organization which was formed in 1998 through the merger of 3 real estate bodies, namely the Association of Singapore Realtors (ASR), the Association of Singapore Real Estate Agents (ASREA) and the Society of Singapore Institute of Surveyors and Valuers Accredited Estate Agents (SOCREA).

The mission of IEA is to represent the real estate profession. Its objective is to promote and advance the interest of its members as well as to protect the interest of the public in the engagement of members for real estate services.

Telephone number: +65 6323 1770

Email: secretariat@iea.sg

Website: <https://iea.sg/>

Consumers Association of Singapore (CASE)

The Consumers Association of Singapore (CASE) is a non-profit, non-governmental organisation that is committed towards protecting consumers interest through information and education, and promoting an environment of fair and ethical trade practices. One of our key achievements is in advocating for the Consumer Protection (Fair Trading) Act (CPFTA) which came into effect on March 1, 2004.

CASE Consumer Hotline: +65 9795 8397

Website: www.case.org.sg

Small Claims Tribunals of Singapore

The Small Claims Tribunals (the “Tribunals”) are part of the State Courts of Singapore. The Tribunals were established on 1 February 1985 to provide a quick and inexpensive forum for the resolution of small claims between consumers and suppliers.

Telephone number: +65 6587 8423

Website: <https://www.judiciary.gov.sg/civil/small-claims>

OTHER RESOURCES:

- Common Property Renting Mistake:
www.99.co/blog/singapore/common-property-renting-mistake/
- Settling Rental Disputes:

www.99.co/blog/singapore/small-claims-tribunal-rental-disputes/